the roads snaking through them, and asked, ‘What could be their possible location now? How much time do we have?’

Ragothaman said, ‘Villupuram to Madras by bus is five hours. Krishnamurthy called me around seven on 13 June 1991. Presuming Nalini boarded by five, they should be close to Madras by now.’

Everyone present realized they were racing against time, with only two hours in hand.

Kaarthikeyan said, ‘We have only an hour in hand to plan, prepare and take positions at strategic points. Our focus will be on Saidapet bus terminus.’

To begin with, he decided to send teams to Bhagyanathan’s printing press, the Vilivakkam house where Nalini lived and her mother Padma’s house in West Mambalam, where she lived earlier.

Kaarthikeyan underlined, ‘We must catch them alive.’ He turned to the NSG captain. ‘Ravindran, your boys are trained in close-combat strategies—you have to stop them from biting the cyanide pills.’ And then, in his inimitable style, added, ‘Dismissed.’ The officers split into multiple teams.

Verma and Ragothaman probed Koneswaran about the possibility of Nalini and Murugan taking cyanide. He confirmed that Murugan would have one on his person; however, he wasn’t sure of Nalini doing the same since it required a certain mindset that, in his words, ‘Only an LTTE cadre has.’ Nalini’s brother Bhagyanathan, now in custody, denied that his sister ever carried a cyanide pill. Ragothaman sat across from Nalini’s mother Padma and asked her the same question. She echoed what her son had just told Verma.

Ravindran did a quick mock drill with omega-3 capsules with his Black Cat commandos—how to prevent a target from biting cyanide and preventing arrest. It wasn’t easy, with the available time between two and three seconds.

Kaarthikeyan supervised the CRPF Cobra commandos as they stocked up on ammunition. Armed Tamil Nadu Police, led by Manoharan, geared up as well. While some men were uniformed in khakis and camouflage, others, including the Black Cats, had changed into plain clothes.